

# Unit 8

## The Art of Pitching

3 Slibraries · 15 framework sheets

### SLIBRARY 22 Core Message

5 sheets

- |                                |                      |
|--------------------------------|----------------------|
| 1 Distill-Decompose-Prioritise | 4 Message-Market Fit |
| 2 Message Strategy Spectrum    | 5 One-Sentence Pitch |
| 3 Vehicles for Ideas           |                      |

### SLIBRARY 23 StoryBrand Arc

5 sheets

- |                         |                         |
|-------------------------|-------------------------|
| 1 Miller's 7-Part Story | 4 Before-After-Bridge   |
| 2 Hero's Journey        | 5 Problem-Agitate-Solve |
| 3 Pixar's 6-Step Spine  |                         |

### SLIBRARY 24 10-Slide Deck

5 sheets

- |                         |                         |
|-------------------------|-------------------------|
| 1 Kawasaki's 10/20/30   | 4 Investor Deck Anatomy |
| 2 Sequoia Structure     | 5 3-Minute Pitch        |
| 3 Airbnb Slide Template |                         |

# Distill-Decompose-Prioritise

SLIBRARY 22 · SHEET 1 / 5

Three moves that compress a venture into one sentence

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise is a three-step compression discipline for pitch preparation: *Distill* the venture to its essence by removing supporting detail, *Decompose* the essence into testable component claims, and *Prioritise* claims by audience-relevance. The discipline produces pitches that are short by design rather than by accident — the founder retains everything that matters and removes everything that doesn't, regardless of personal attachment to detail (Heath and Heath, 2007; Dolak, 2003).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Synthesised from Chip and Dan Heath's *Made to Stick* (2007) commander's-intent compression, Dean Dolak's pitch-coaching practice ("Distill, Decompose, Prioritise", 2003), and Bill Aulet's *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* (2013) pitch-design discipline at MIT.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders defaulted to comprehensive pitches that included everything they cared about, defeating the listener's working-memory bandwidth. The three-step discipline forces deliberate compression — keeping the most consequential signal and shedding everything else.

## HOW IT IS USED

Distill: write the venture's one-sentence essence (what the world looks like if you win). Decompose: list the supporting claims (problem, solution, traction). Prioritise: rank by audience-relevance and pitch only the top three.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use before any pitch (investor, customer, internal sponsor), in deck-design workshops, in pitch-coaching sessions, and when founders' pitches consistently lose audience attention before key claims land.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA capstone instructors, and corporate-innovation leaders preparing senior-leadership pitches.

FIGURE 1 · THREE COMPRESSION MOVES

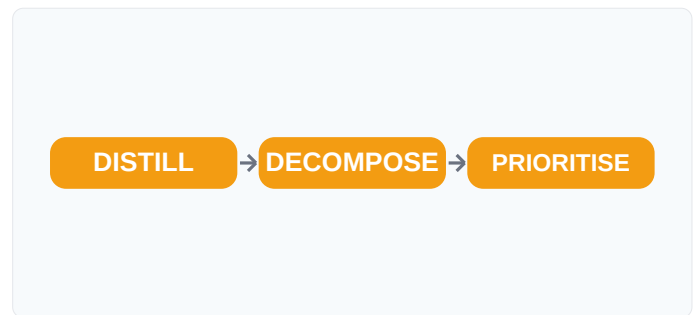


Figure 1. Each move compresses further; the founder removes everything that doesn't earn its place.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Carmine Gallo's (2012) presentation literature emphasised delivery and Tony Buzan's (1974) mind-mapping captured idea structure, the three-step discipline's contribution is compression as a sequenced process. Building on Heath and Heath's (2007) commander's-intent tradition, it makes pitch compression teachable.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Message Strategy Spectrum · Slibrary 22

Message-Market Fit · Slibrary 22

One-Sentence Pitch · Slibrary 22

Vehicles for Ideas · Slibrary 22

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Heath, C. and Heath, D. (2007) *Made to Stick*. New York: Random House.

Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup*. Hoboken: Wiley.

Gallo, C. (2012) *The Apple Experience*. New York: McGraw-Hill.

Buzan, T. (1974) *Use Your Head*. London: BBC Books.

# Message Strategy Spectrum

SLIBRARY 22 · SHEET 2 / 5

Inform · Persuade · Activate · Transform — match strategy to ask

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Message Strategy Spectrum classifies pitch intent along an action-escalation: *Inform* (the audience learns), *Persuade* (the audience changes belief), *Activate* (the audience commits a specific action), *Transform* (the audience changes identity or organisation). Each level requires different evidence, emotional arc and call-to-action structure. Founders default to inform when the situation requires activate — a structural failure mode that the spectrum makes diagnosable (Aristotle, 4th c. BCE; Heath and Heath, 2007).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Synthesised from Aristotle's (4th c. BCE) *Rhetoric* tripartite (logos, pathos, ethos) and McKee's (1997) story-arc theory; the modern startup-pitch articulation traces to Bill Aulet's *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* (2013) and pitch-coaching literature including Dean Dolak's work.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders gave the same pitch regardless of audience and purpose, treating all audiences as needing information. The spectrum forces alignment between the ask (what the audience must do) and the message strategy (what the pitch must produce in the audience).

## HOW IT IS USED

Define the specific ask. Place it on the spectrum. Match message strategy: Inform demands clarity; Persuade demands evidence; Activate demands urgency-and-clear-next-step; Transform demands narrative-arc-and-identity-stakes.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use before designing any pitch, in pitch-coaching sessions, in fundraising-deck design, and in internal-sponsor escalation requests where the ask determines the message strategy.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA capstone instructors, and corporate communications professionals.

FIGURE 1 · FOUR STRATEGY LEVELS

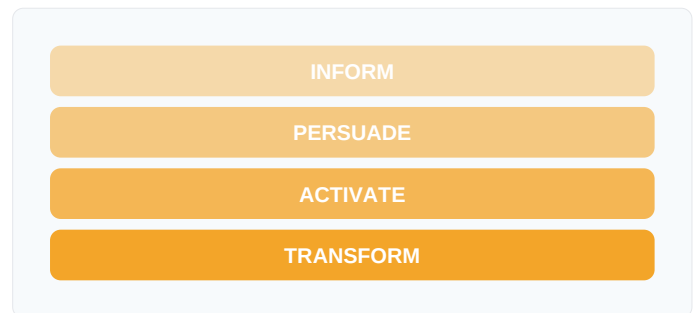


Figure 1. Each level requires different evidence and emotional arc; mismatching level to ask is a structural failure mode.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Aristotle's (4th c. BCE) rhetorical triangle distinguished modes of persuasion and Cialdini's (1984) influence research catalogued tactics, the Message Strategy Spectrum's contribution is matching the ask to a specific message-design strategy. Building on McKee's (1997) story-arc tradition, it gives pitch designers an actionable typology.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise · Slibrary 22

Message-Market Fit · Slibrary 22

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Pixar's 6-Step Spine · Slibrary 23

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

- Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Aristotle (4th c. BCE) *Rhetoric*. Translated by W.R. Roberts. Oxford: Clarendon, 1924.  
 Heath, C. and Heath, D. (2007) *Made to Stick*. New York: Random House.  
 Cialdini, R.B. (1984) *Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion*. New York: Morrow.

# Vehicles for Ideas

SLIBRARY 22 · SHEET 3 / 5

Story · Demo · Data · Metaphor · Prototype — pick the right carrier

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Vehicles for Ideas are the carrier formats through which a pitch's content reaches the audience: *Story* (narrative arc), *Demo* (live product), *Data* (quantitative evidence), *Metaphor* (analogy from a known domain), *Prototype* (tangible artefact). Each vehicle has different strengths: stories travel well, demos prove feasibility, data persuades sceptics, metaphors compress unfamiliar concepts, prototypes resolve uncertainty. Strong pitches stack 2–3 vehicles for the same message (Heath and Heath, 2007; Gallo, 2014).

### WHO DEVELOPED IT

Synthesised from Chip and Dan Heath's *Made to Stick* (2007) on memorable messages, Carmine Gallo's *Talk Like TED* (2014) on multi-vehicle TED talks, and pitch-coaching literature traceable to Garr Reynolds's *Presentation Zen* (2008).

### WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders defaulted to one vehicle (usually data) and audiences disengaged. Multiple vehicles for the same message engage different cognitive modes — narrative memory, evidence verification, working-memory unloading via metaphor, sensory grounding via demo — multiplying retention and persuasion.

### HOW IT IS USED

For each pitch claim, ask which vehicles best carry it. Stack 2–3 vehicles per major claim. Avoid vehicle fatigue (no more than two consecutive demos, etc.). Match vehicle to audience cognitive style.

### WHEN IT IS USED

Use in pitch-design, in keynote preparation, in internal-stakeholder communication, and as a check against single-vehicle pitches that fail to land with diverse audiences.

### BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, presentation designers, corporate communicators, and MBA students designing capstone pitches.

FIGURE 1 · FIVE CARRIERS

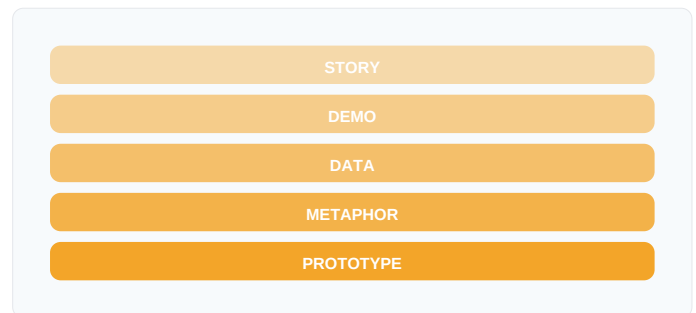


Figure 1. Each vehicle engages a different cognitive mode; stacking 2–3 multiplies retention and persuasion.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Aristotle's (4th c. BCE) rhetorical modes treated logos/pathos/ethos as the toolkit and Mehrabian's (1971) communication research showed channel diversity, the modern vehicles framework's contribution is the multi-vehicle stacking discipline for single messages. Building on Reynolds's (2008) presentation-design work, it gives pitch designers an actionable carrier-matrix.

### RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise · Slibrary 22

Message Strategy Spectrum · Slibrary 22

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Airbnb Slide Template · Slibrary 24

### SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Heath, C. and Heath, D. (2007) *Made to Stick*. New York: Random House.  
 Gallo, C. (2014) *Talk Like TED*. New York: St. Martin's Press.  
 Reynolds, G. (2008) *Presentation Zen*. Berkeley: New Riders.  
 Mehrabian, A. (1971) *Silent Messages*. Belmont: Wadsworth.

# Message-Market Fit

SLIBRARY 22 · SHEET 4 / 5

*The pitch fits the audience — investor vs customer vs internal need different messages*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Message-Market Fit is the alignment between a pitch's content, structure and emotional arc and the specific decision-relevance of the target audience. Investors need risk-and-return signals; customers need problem-solution-and-trust signals; internal sponsors need strategic-fit-and-political-cover signals. The same venture requires three structurally different pitches; using one for all audiences is the most common pitch failure (Andreessen, 2007; Aulet, 2013).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Synthesised from Bill Aulet's *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* (2013), Marc Andreessen's product-market-fit framing (2007) extended to messages, and pitch-coaching practice at YC, Techstars and corporate accelerators. Conceptual roots in Levitt's (1960) marketing-myopia critique.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders crafted one pitch and reused it across audiences, optimising for none. Message-market-fit thinking forces audience-segmented pitch design — three structurally different pitches for the same venture, each optimised for the audience's specific decision criteria.

## HOW IT IS USED

Identify the audience's decision criteria. Map the venture's claims against those criteria. Cut claims that don't address criteria; expand claims that do. Iterate the pitch separately for investor, customer, and internal-sponsor audiences.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use before any pitch, in fundraising-cycle pitch design, in customer-pitch development, in internal-sponsorship escalation, and as a diagnostic when pitches consistently underperform with specific audiences.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, B2B sales leaders, and corporate-communications professionals managing multi-audience messaging.

FIGURE 1 · THREE AUDIENCES

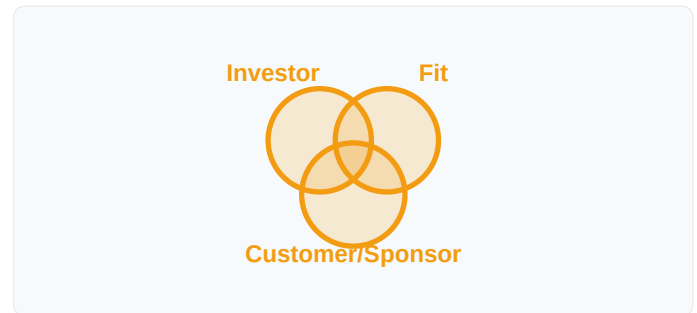


Figure 1. The same venture requires three structurally different pitches; one pitch for all audiences fails all of them.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where traditional marketing distinguished segment-specific positioning (Ries and Trout, 1981), the Message-Market Fit concept's contribution is its application to pitch-as-a-product. Building on Andreessen's (2007) product-market-fit framing, it makes audience-pitch matching a deliberate design discipline.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise · Slibrary 22

Message Strategy Spectrum · Slibrary 22

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

- Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Andreessen, M. (2007) 'The Only Thing That Matters', *pmarchive.com*.  
 Ries, A. and Trout, J. (1981) *Positioning: The Battle for Your Mind*. New York: McGraw-Hill.  
 Levitt, T. (1960) 'Marketing Myopia', *Harvard Business Review*, 38(4), pp. 45–56.

# One-Sentence Pitch

SLIBRARY 22 · SHEET 5 / 5

We help [WHO] do [WHAT] by [HOW] — fit it on a business card

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The One-Sentence Pitch is a structured single-sentence venture description in the form: "We help [target customer] do [job-to-be-done] by [unique mechanism]." The format forces clarity on three variables that loose pitches conflate: who exactly, what exactly, and how exactly. The discipline isn't brevity for its own sake but compression that exposes whether the founder actually knows the answers (Aulet, 2013; Maurya, 2012).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

The structured format traces to multiple sources: Geoffrey Moore's positioning template in *Crossing the Chasm* (1991), Bill Aulet's MIT pitch templates (2013), and Ash Maurya's Lean Canvas-derived elevator pitch (2012). The form is now standard across accelerator and MBA pitch curricula.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders described their ventures in vague terms ("we use AI to disrupt healthcare") that signalled buzz without commitment. The one-sentence template forces commitment on three specific variables — making vagueness impossible to hide and exposing where the founder doesn't yet know.

## HOW IT IS USED

Fill the template: "We help [WHO] do [WHAT] by [HOW]." Test against the discipline: is WHO specific (a segment, not a market)? Is WHAT a job (not a feature)? Is HOW a mechanism (not a technology category)? Iterate until all three pass.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use as the foundation for any longer pitch, on business cards and home-page hero sections, in internal-pitch openings, and as a diagnostic when a venture cannot be described concisely.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, marketing leaders writing positioning statements, and MBA students learning pitch craft.

## FIGURE 1 · THREE SLOTS

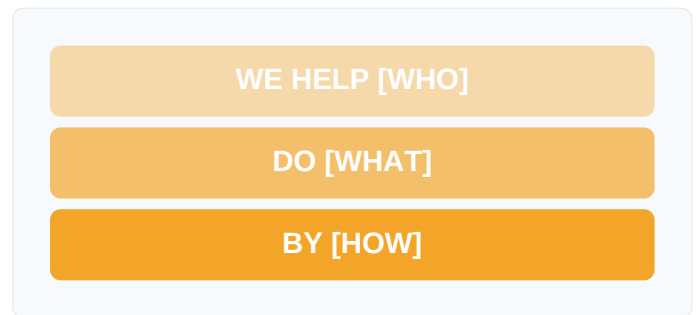


Figure 1. Each slot must be specific; vagueness in any slot signals the founder doesn't yet know.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Moore's (1991) positioning template was a marketing-strategy tool and traditional elevator-pitch coaching was unstructured, the modern WHO-WHAT-HOW form's contribution is exposing knowledge gaps through forced commitment. Building on Heath and Heath's (2007) commander's-intent compression, it became the canonical pitch foundation.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise · Slibrary 22

Message-Market Fit · Slibrary 22

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Maurya, A. (2012) *Running Lean*. 2nd edn. Sebastopol: O'Reilly.  
 Moore, G.A. (1991) *Crossing the Chasm*. New York: HarperBusiness.  
 Heath, C. and Heath, D. (2007) *Made to Stick*. New York: Random House.

# Miller's 7-Part Story

SLIBRARY 23 · SHEET 1 / 5

*Hero · Problem · Guide · Plan · Action · Failure · Success*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Donald Miller's StoryBrand is a seven-part narrative framework for venture messaging: a *Hero* (the customer, not the company) has a *Problem* and meets a *Guide* (the company) who gives them a *Plan* and calls them to *Action* resulting in either *Failure* (status quo consequence) or *Success* (transformation). The structural insight is that the customer is the hero of the story, not the company — inverting most marketing's company-as-hero default (Miller, 2017).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Donald Miller, founder of StoryBrand, in *Building a StoryBrand* (2017). Built on Joseph Campbell's (1949) hero's-journey monomyth, Christopher Vogler's (1992) screenwriter adaptation, and decades of marketing-narrative literature.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Most marketing positioned the company as the hero of its own story — protagonist defeating problems through superior capabilities. Miller's reframe treats the customer as hero and the company as guide. This places customer transformation, not company achievement, at the centre of the narrative.

## HOW IT IS USED

Map each marketing message into the 7-part structure: who is the hero (the customer)? What's their problem (external, internal, philosophical)? Who is the guide (the company)? What's the plan? The action? The stakes (failure vs success)?

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in marketing-narrative redesign, in pitch-deck story-arc design, in homepage-hero sections, and whenever a brand's messaging defaults to company-as-hero.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders writing marketing copy, marketing leaders, brand strategists, pitch coaches, and copywriters designing customer-facing communications.

## FIGURE 1 · SEVEN PARTS

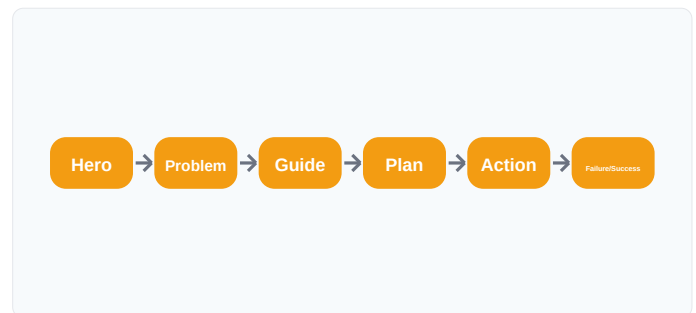


Figure 1. The customer is the hero, the company is the guide. Adapted from Miller (2017).

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Joseph Campbell (1949) traced the hero's journey across mythologies and Vogler (1992) applied it to screenwriting, Miller's contribution is the customer-as-hero inversion specifically for marketing. Building on Aaker's (1996) brand-personality literature, it gave story-arc-driven messaging a teachable seven-part template.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Hero's Journey · Slibrary 23

Pixar's 6-Step Spine · Slibrary 23

Before-After-Bridge · Slibrary 23

Problem-Agitate-Solve · Slibrary 23

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Miller, D. (2017) *Building a StoryBrand*. New York: HarperCollins Leadership.  
 Campbell, J. (1949) *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*. New York: Pantheon.  
 Vogler, C. (1992) *The Writer's Journey*. Studio City: Michael Wiese Productions.  
 Aaker, D.A. (1996) *Building Strong Brands*. New York: Free Press.

# Hero's Journey

SLIBRARY 23 · SHEET 2 / 5

Campbell's monomyth — Departure · Initiation · Return

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Joseph Campbell's Hero's Journey (or monomyth) is a narrative structure traced across world mythologies: a hero leaves the ordinary world, faces trials, gains a transformative reward, and returns home changed. The journey has seventeen sub-stages traditionally compressed to three acts — Departure, Initiation, Return. The structure's resonance across cultures suggests deep cognitive grounding; in pitch contexts, it provides a narrative arc that sustains audience attention through complex venture stories (Campbell, 1949; Vogler, 1992).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Joseph Campbell, comparative-mythology scholar, in *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949). Christopher Vogler adapted the structure for Hollywood screenwriting in *The Writer's Journey* (1992), making it the dominant story structure of late-20th-century film.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Campbell sought the universal pattern beneath culturally diverse hero stories; his finding was the monomyth's near-universality. Vogler's adaptation made the structure operationally usable for storytellers in pitch, marketing and entertainment contexts seeking narrative arcs that resonate cross-culturally.

## HOW IT IS USED

Map the venture story onto the three acts: Departure (the founder's pre-venture world and call to adventure), Initiation (the trials of building, near-failures, key insights), Return (the venture's current state and the transformation it offers). Compress for pitch length.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in long-form founder-story pitches, in keynote-style fundraising decks, in narrative-driven brand storytelling, and in capstone-pitch performances where audience time and attention permit narrative depth.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders crafting personal-and-venture origin stories, pitch coaches working on long-form pitches, brand storytellers, and corporate-communications leaders shaping CEO narratives.

FIGURE 1 · THREE ACTS

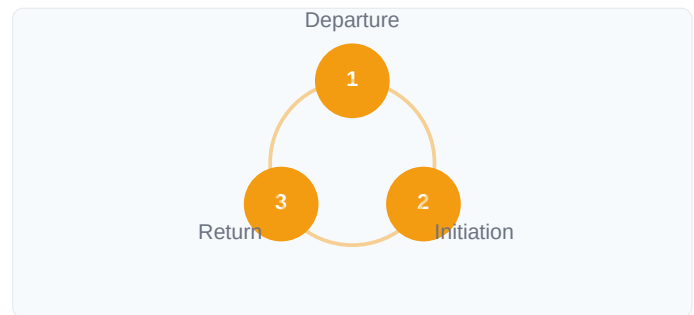


Figure 1. The monomyth's three acts compress 17 sub-stages into a teachable narrative structure. Adapted from Campbell (1949).

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where pre-Campbell mythology was studied culture-by-culture and pre-Vogler screenwriting taught Aristotelian three-act structure (4th c. BCE), Campbell's contribution is the universal pattern beneath both. Building on Jung's (1959) archetype theory, the monomyth gives storytellers a teachable cross-cultural structure.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Pixar's 6-Step Spine · Slibrary 23

Problem-Agitate-Solve · Slibrary 23

Before-After-Bridge · Slibrary 23

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Campbell, J. (1949) *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*. New York: Pantheon.  
 Vogler, C. (1992) *The Writer's Journey*. Studio City: Michael Wiese Productions.  
 Jung, C.G. (1959) *The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.  
 McKee, R. (1997) *Story*. New York: HarperCollins.

# Pixar's 6-Step Spine

SLIBRARY 23 · SHEET 3 / 5

*Once upon a time · Every day · Until one day · Because of that · Until finally · Ever since then*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Pixar's 6-Step Story Spine, refined by writer Emma Coats during her time at Pixar Animation Studios, is a six-sentence narrative scaffold: *Once upon a time...* establishes the hero's world; *Every day...* establishes routine; *Until one day...* introduces the disruption; *Because of that...* chains consequences (typically twice); *Until finally...* resolves the disruption; *Ever since then...* establishes the new normal. The spine produces compelling stories with minimal training (Coats, 2011).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Emma Coats, while a story artist at Pixar, in her 2011 "22 Story Basics" Twitter thread. Builds on Pixar's institutional storytelling discipline (Catmull, 2014), Kenn Adams's earlier improvisational "story spine" (1991), and Stanislavski's (1936) acting-method beats.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Storytellers without formal training defaulted to chronological event-recitation rather than story arcs with stakes. Coats's six-sentence form provided a scaffold that any first-time storyteller could fill, producing real narrative arcs with minimal craft training.

## HOW IT IS USED

Fill in each of the six sentences for the venture story. Iterate until each sentence does its specific structural work. Test by reading aloud — strong spines produce listener anticipation at "until one day" and resolution at "until finally".

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in venture-origin storytelling, in keynote-pitch design, in marketing-narrative workshops, and as a teaching scaffold in MBA pitch courses for students new to narrative craft.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, marketing leaders, pitch coaches, MBA capstone instructors, and content marketers writing brand-story copy.

## FIGURE 1 · SIX SENTENCES



Figure 1. Six sentences scaffold a real story arc; the form makes narrative craft teachable to first-time pitchers.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Aristotelian three-act structure (4th c. BCE) and Campbell's (1949) monomyth required craft-mastery to apply, Coats's contribution is the six-sentence scaffold that any beginner can fill. Building on improvisational story-spine traditions (Adams, 1991), it gives pitch designers an entry-level narrative tool.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Hero's Journey · Slibrary 23

Before-After-Bridge · Slibrary 23

Problem-Agitate-Solve · Slibrary 23

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Coats, E. (2011) '22 Story Basics', *Twitter* / *pixar.tumblr.com*.

Catmull, E. (2014) *Creativity, Inc.*. New York: Random House.

Adams, K. (1991) 'The Story Spine', *Improvisational Theatre Newsletter*.

McKee, R. (1997) *Story*. New York: HarperCollins.

# Before-After-Bridge

SLIBRARY 23 · SHEET 4 / 5

*Before pain · After dream · Bridge offer*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Before-After-Bridge (BAB) is a three-part copy and pitch structure: paint the customer's *Before* (current pain, vivid and specific), paint their *After* (desired future, equally vivid), and present the venture as the *Bridge* from one to the other. The structure compresses StoryBrand and Pixar's longer arcs into three beats — short enough for landing-page heroes, long enough for emotional resonance. BAB is the workhorse of conversion copywriting (Bly, 1985; Kennedy, 1990).

### WHO DEVELOPED IT

BAB has roots in direct-response copywriting practice (Robert Bly's *The Copywriter's Handbook*, 1985; Dan Kennedy's *The Ultimate Sales Letter*, 1990); the modern BAB framing was popularised by Joanna Wiebe at Copyhackers (2010s) and is standard in conversion-copywriting and pitch-design literature.

### WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Long-form story structures (Hero's Journey, StoryBrand) didn't fit landing-page hero sections or 30-second pitches. BAB compresses the same emotional arc — current pain, desired future, bridge offer — into three beats that work in any medium.

### HOW IT IS USED

Write *Before* in customer's specific painful language. Write *After* in their specific dreamed-of language. Present the offer as the *Bridge* from *Before* to *After*. Test variants for specificity — vague *Before*s fail, specific ones convert.

### WHEN IT IS USED

Use in landing-page hero copy, in 30-second pitches, in cold-email opens, in pricing-page copy, and as the underlying arc for any short-form persuasion.

### BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders writing landing-page copy, growth marketers, copywriters, sales-enablement leaders, and pitch coaches.

## FIGURE 1 · THREE BEATS



Figure 1. Three beats compress a full emotional arc; the bridge is always the offer.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Bly's (1985) AIDA funnel emphasised attention-interest-desire-action and traditional copywriting taught feature-benefit pairs, BAB's contribution is the emotional-arc compression with bridge-as-offer. Building on Lerma's (1944) before-after advertising tradition, it became the conversion-copy default.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Problem-Agitate-Solve · Slibrary 23

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Pixar's 6-Step Spine · Slibrary 23

One-Sentence Pitch · Slibrary 22

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Bly, R.W. (1985) *The Copywriter's Handbook*. New York: Henry Holt.  
 Kennedy, D.S. (1990) *The Ultimate Sales Letter*. Avon: Adams Media.  
 Wiebe, J. (2017) *Copyhackers Conversion Copywriting Course*. Copyhackers.  
 Sugarman, J. (2007) *The Adweek Copywriting Handbook*. Hoboken: Wiley.

# Problem-Agitate-Solve

SLIBRARY 23 · SHEET 5 / 5

PAS — surface the problem, deepen the pain, present the cure

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Problem-Agitate-Solve (PAS) is a three-part copy structure: *state the problem* the audience faces, *agitate* by intensifying the consequences if it goes unsolved, then *solve* with the venture's offer. The structure is older than BAB and more confrontational — agitation makes the cost of inaction vivid before the solution arrives. PAS works particularly well in B2B contexts where the problem is significant but the customer has been tolerating it (Sugarman, 2007; Cialdini, 1984).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

PAS has direct-response copywriting roots traceable to Eugene Schwartz's *Breakthrough Advertising* (1966) and was systematised by Joseph Sugarman in *The Adweek Copywriting Handbook* (2007). The modern version is standard in B2B-marketing and sales-enablement training.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Customers tolerating chronic problems didn't recognise the cost of inaction. Pure problem-statement copy didn't move them; agitation forced explicit reckoning with what tolerating the problem actually cost — opening psychological space for the solution.

## HOW IT IS USED

State the problem in the customer's exact language. Agitate by detailing specific costs of inaction (financial, reputational, opportunity). Present the solution as the cure — direct, actionable, immediate.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in B2B marketing where the problem is chronic, in sales-pitch openings, in long-form sales letters, and in pitch decks targeting investors who need the problem's stakes made vivid.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

B2B marketers, copywriters, sales-enablement leaders, founders writing investor-pitch problem slides, and sales-development representatives crafting outbound sequences.

## FIGURE 1 · THREE BEATS

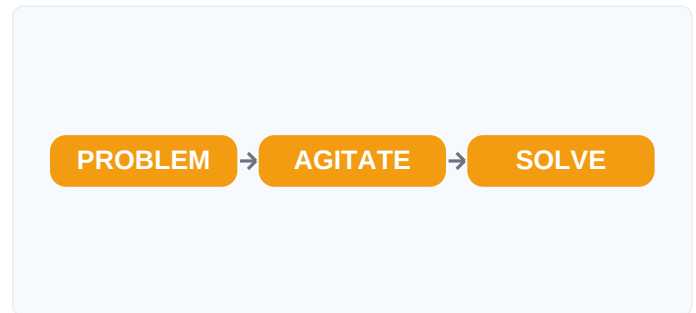


Figure 1. Agitation makes inaction's cost vivid; the solution arrives only after the cost is explicit.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Bly's (1985) AIDA funnel didn't include agitation explicitly and Maslow's (1954) needs-hierarchy framed motivation abstractly, Sugarman's contribution is the explicit pain-amplification step. Building on Schwartz's (1966) breakthrough-advertising traditions and Cialdini's (1984) influence research, PAS became the B2B copy default.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Before-After-Bridge · Slibrary 23

Miller's 7-Part Story · Slibrary 23

Hero's Journey · Slibrary 23

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Sugarman, J. (2007) *The Adweek Copywriting Handbook*. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Schwartz, E. (1966) *Breakthrough Advertising*. New York: Boardroom.  
 Cialdini, R.B. (1984) *Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion*. New York: Morrow.  
 Bly, R.W. (1985) *The Copywriter's Handbook*. New York: Henry Holt.

# Kawasaki's 10/20/30

SLIBRARY 24 · SHEET 1 / 5

10 slides · 20 minutes · 30-point font — Guy Kawasaki's rule

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Guy Kawasaki's 10/20/30 Rule prescribes pitch deck constraints: at most *10 slides*, presented in *20 minutes*, with text at minimum *30-point font*. The constraints force compression that defeats the founder's instinct to add slides, take more time, and shrink fonts to fit text. Each constraint is engineered to enforce the others — 10 slides limits depth, 20 minutes limits drift, 30-point font limits text density (Kawasaki, 2004, 2015).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Guy Kawasaki, former Apple chief evangelist and venture capitalist, in his 2004 book *The Art of the Start* and elaborated in *The Art of the Start 2.0* (2015). The 10/20/30 rule emerged from Kawasaki's experience reviewing thousands of pitch decks at Garage Technology Ventures.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Kawasaki sat through hundreds of pitches over-running their time slots, packed with 50+ slides, and using 8-point font. The 10/20/30 rule was his prescriptive answer: explicit limits that founders could not negotiate, forcing the discipline that quality pitch design requires.

## HOW IT IS USED

Build the deck within all three constraints simultaneously. Each constraint is a structural test — if the deck exceeds 10 slides, content is too thin per slide; if it exceeds 20 minutes, pacing is wrong; if fonts shrink below 30 points, content per slide is too dense.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in fundraising-pitch design, in board-presentation preparation, in conference-talk preparation, and as a teaching constraint in pitch courses where students default to overlong, dense, slow decks.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA capstone instructors, and corporate-communications professionals preparing senior-leadership pitches.

## FIGURE 1 · THREE CONSTRAINTS

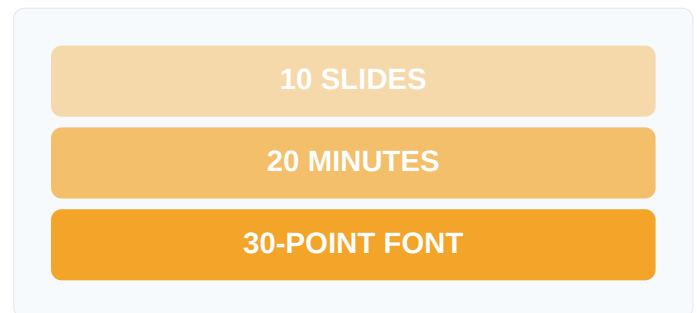


Figure 1. Each constraint enforces the others; together they impose pitch-design discipline. Adapted from Kawasaki (2004).

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where pre-2004 pitch advice was unstructured craft talk, Kawasaki's contribution is the prescriptive triple constraint. Building on Tufte's (1990) information-density tradition (inverting it for pitch contexts), it gave founders a memorable, enforceable design discipline.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Sequoia Structure · Slibrary 24

Airbnb Slide Template · Slibrary 24

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kawasaki, G. (2004) *The Art of the Start*. New York: Portfolio.  
 Kawasaki, G. (2015) *The Art of the Start 2.0*. New York: Portfolio.  
 Reynolds, G. (2008) *Presentation Zen*. Berkeley: New Riders.  
 Tufte, E.R. (1990) *Envisioning Information*. Cheshire: Graphics Press.

# Sequoia Structure

SLIBRARY 24 · SHEET 2 / 5

*Company purpose · Problem · Solution · Why Now · Market · Competition · Product · Team · Financials*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Sequoia Capital's standard pitch-deck template covers ten sections in fixed order: *Company Purpose* (one sentence), *Problem*, *Solution*, *Why Now* (timing), *Market Size*, *Competition*, *Product* (demo), *Business Model*, *Team*, *Financials*. The template is the most-imitated pitch structure in venture capital because it answers the questions investors actually ask, in the order they ask them. Founders ignoring the order frustrate audience expectations (Sequoia Capital, 2008).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Sequoia Capital, the long-running Silicon Valley venture capital firm (founded 1972), published the template publicly in 2008. Synthesises Sequoia's pattern across thousands of pitches funded over four decades, including Apple, Cisco, Google, PayPal, YouTube and WhatsApp.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders structured pitches according to their own logic, missing the investor's logic. Sequoia made the investor's question-order public, giving founders a template that pre-answered investor questions in the right sequence — reducing back-and-forth and increasing pitch effectiveness.

## HOW IT IS USED

Build the deck in Sequoia's exact section order. Each section has a specific question to answer; cover only that question per section. Adapt content but preserve order — the order itself is the value.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in any investor pitch, in fundraising deck design, in pitch-coaching sessions, and as the default deck structure when pitching VCs.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders raising VC capital, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, and MBA capstone instructors.

FIGURE 1 · TEN SECTIONS

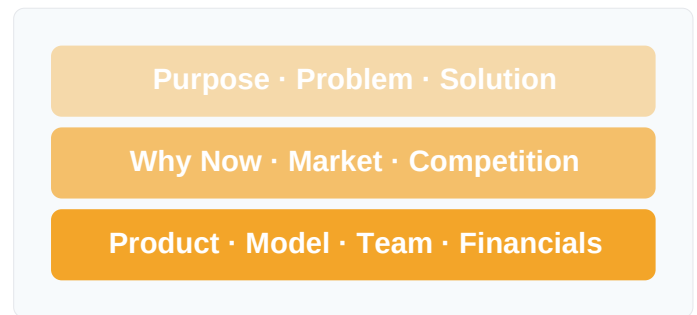


Figure 1. The order itself is the value; investors expect this sequence.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Kawasaki's (2004) 10/20/30 rule prescribed constraints without specifying content order, Sequoia's contribution is the question-order matched to investor cognition. Building on the standard NPV-and-strategy diligence sequence VCs follow, it gave founders an investor-friendly template.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Kawasaki's 10/20/30 · Slibrary 24

Airbnb Slide Template · Slibrary 24

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Sequoia Capital (2008) *Writing a Business Plan*. Sequoia Capital.  
 Kawasaki, G. (2015) *The Art of the Start 2.0*. New York: Portfolio.  
 Feld, B. and Mendelson, J. (2022) *Venture Deals*. 5th edn. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.

# Airbnb Slide Template

SLIBRARY 24 · SHEET 3 / 5

Brian Chesky's original 10-slide deck — the most-studied pitch in VC history

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Airbnb Slide Template refers to Brian Chesky's original 10-slide pitch deck used to raise Airbnb's \$600K seed round in 2009. The deck became the most-studied pitch in venture capital because of Airbnb's subsequent scale and the deck's elegant compression: each slide answered exactly one investor question, total text was minimal, and traction (which existed) led the deck. The template is now imitated by founders in every category (Chesky, 2009; Gallo, 2018).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Brian Chesky, Joe Gebbia, and Nathan Blecharczyk for Airbnb's 2009 seed round. The deck became publicly studied through Reid Hoffman's annotated version on LinkedIn (2016) and Carmine Gallo's analysis in *Five Stars* (2018).

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Chesky's deck demonstrated that early-stage decks could be both visually elegant and analytically rigorous. The template's wide imitation reflects its specific design choices: ten slides, one claim per slide, minimal text, traction-led, problem-stated-before-solution.

## FIGURE 1 · TEN SLIDES

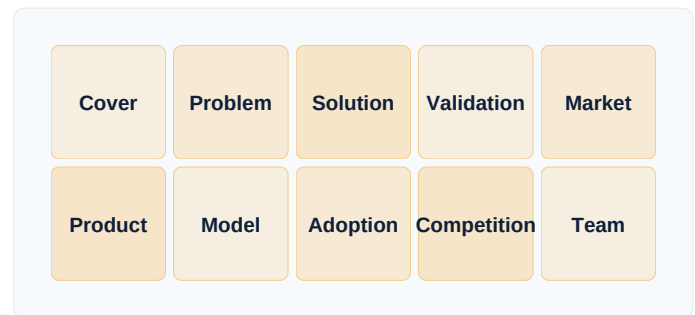


Figure 1. Each slide answers one investor question; minimal text, traction-led.

## HOW IT IS USED

Adapt each of the ten Airbnb slides: *Cover* · *Problem* · *Solution* · *Market Validation* · *Market Size* · *Product* · *Business Model* · *Market Adoption* · *Competition* · *Team*. Lead with traction if it exists; lead with problem if not. One claim per slide, minimal text.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use in seed-round pitch design, as a study reference for pitch coaches, in MBA capstone deck preparation, and as a comparative anchor when reviewing other pitch decks.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders raising seed capital, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA instructors, and venture-capital partners using the deck as a teaching anchor for portfolio companies.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Sequoia's (2008) template prescribed structure abstractly, the Airbnb deck's contribution is a fully-realised concrete example that founders can imitate slide-by-slide. Building on Sequoia's structure with traction-led Chesky modifications, it became the most-imitated pitch design of the 2010s.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Kawasaki's 10/20/30 · Slibrary 24

Sequoia Structure · Slibrary 24

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Chesky, B. (2009) *Airbnb Pitch Deck*. Available on multiple archive sources.

Gallo, C. (2018) *Five Stars: The Communication Secrets to Get from Good to Great*. New York: St. Martin's Press.

Hoffman, R. (2016) 'Annotated Airbnb Pitch Deck', *LinkedIn*.

Sequoia Capital (2008) *Writing a Business Plan*. Sequoia Capital.

# Investor Deck Anatomy

SLIBRARY 24 · SHEET 4 / 5

Hook · Problem · Solution · Market · Model · Team · Ask

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Investor Deck Anatomy is the seven-element compressed structure underlying most successful seed-stage pitches: *Hook* (memorable opening), *Problem* (size and severity), *Solution* (mechanism and demo), *Market* (TAM/SAM/SOM), *Business Model* (how you make money), *Team* (why you), *Ask* (how much, what for). Variations of this anatomy appear in every successful pitch-deck template (Sequoia, Airbnb, Y Combinator). The seven elements answer investors' actual diligence questions (Aulet, 2013; Feld and Mendelson, 2022).

### WHO DEVELOPED IT

Synthesised across multiple pitch-coaching traditions: Bill Aulet's *Disciplined Entrepreneurship* (2013) at MIT, Brad Feld's *Venture Deals* (2022), Y Combinator's standard deck guidance (Graham, 2013), and Sequoia Capital's (2008) template. Each tradition reaches a similar 7-element synthesis from different starting points.

### WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Founders' instincts produced decks that omitted critical investor questions (often Ask, Team, or Market) or over-weighted personally fascinating sections (often Solution). The seven-element anatomy ensures every key question is answered without over- or under-investment in any single section.

### HOW IT IS USED

Build the deck around the seven elements with proportional time/slides per element. Test against the diligence-question checklist: does the deck answer hook, problem, solution, market, model, team, and ask? Cut or expand to balance.

### WHEN IT IS USED

Use in seed and Series A deck design, in pitch-coaching workshops, in MBA capstone deck reviews, and as a structural check on any pitch deck.

### BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA capstone instructors, and venture-capital partners advising portfolio companies on pitch design.

FIGURE 1 · SEVEN ELEMENTS

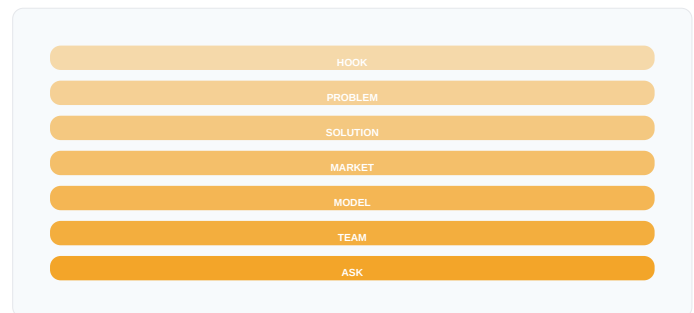


Figure 1. Each element answers a specific investor question; balance prevents over- or under-investment.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Kawasaki's (2004) 10/20/30 prescribed constraints and Sequoia's (2008) template prescribed exact section order, the seven-element anatomy's contribution is the audience-question-driven compression that adapts across stages. Building on Aulet's (2013) MIT teaching tradition, it became standard pitch-coach guidance.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Kawasaki's 10/20/30 · Slibrary 24

Sequoia Structure · Slibrary 24

Airbnb Slide Template · Slibrary 24

3-Minute Pitch · Slibrary 24

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.

Feld, B. and Mendelson, J. (2022) *Venture Deals*. 5th edn. Hoboken: Wiley.

Graham, P. (2013) 'How to Present to Investors', *paulgraham.com*.

Sequoia Capital (2008) *Writing a Business Plan*. Sequoia Capital.

# 3-Minute Pitch

SLIBRARY 24 · SHEET 5 / 5

180 seconds · one slide per 18 seconds · single ask

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The 3-Minute Pitch is the standard format for accelerator demo days, capstone pitch competitions, and angel-investor speed pitches: 180 seconds, 8–10 slides, one ask. The constraint is brutal — 18 seconds per slide forces extreme content selection. The format favours founders who have completed Distill-Decompose-Prioritise discipline; founders who haven't will lose the audience by minute two. The 3-minute pitch is not a shortened version of the long pitch; it is a different artefact (Aulet, 2013; Cohen, 2013).

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

The 3-minute format emerged from Y Combinator's Demo Day (2005, Paul Graham) and was standardised across accelerators worldwide through the 2010s. Coaching practice at Bill Aulet's MIT Trust Center, Techstars, and corporate accelerators codified the form.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Demo Days had hundreds of pitches per day; longer formats made attendance impossible. The 3-minute format respected investor time, forced founder discipline, and produced reliable evidence of which founders had completed the compression work.

## HOW IT IS USED

Pre-write to the 180-second clock. 8–10 slides at 18 seconds each. Single clear ask in the closing 20 seconds. Practise to the second; demo days do not extend. Treat the pitch as a complete artefact, not a compressed long pitch.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Use at demo days, in pitch competitions, in angel-investor speed-pitch nights, in capstone-presentation contexts, and as a forcing function for compression discipline.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders preparing demo days, pitch coaches, accelerator programme directors, MBA capstone instructors, and competition judges.

FIGURE 1 · 180-SECOND ANATOMY

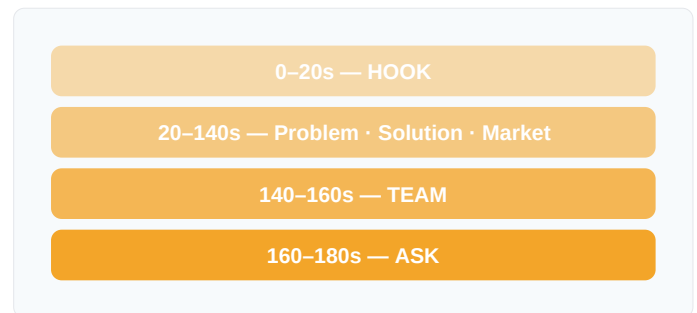


Figure 1. The 3-minute pitch is a complete artefact, not a compressed long pitch.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

Where Kawasaki's (2004) 10/20/30 was a 20-minute format and traditional investor pitches ran 30+ minutes, the 3-minute pitch's contribution is the discipline-forcing extreme compression. Building on TED's (2006) 18-minute talk format extended further, it became the demo-day standard.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Kawasaki's 10/20/30 · Slibrary 24

Investor Deck Anatomy · Slibrary 24

Distill-Decompose-Prioritise · Slibrary 22

Demo Day · Slibrary 21

## SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

- Aulet, B. (2013) *Disciplined Entrepreneurship*. Hoboken: Wiley.  
 Cohen, S. (2013) 'What Do Accelerators Do?', *Innovations*, 8(3–4), pp. 19–25.  
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 Gallo, C. (2014) *Talk Like TED*. New York: St. Martin's Press.